tour. That wasn't a success either, and the band had to busk on the streets once the money ran out. Without a drum kit of his own, Gurtu played on whatever he could find—pots and pans, literally. Undeterred, he applied to the Berklee College of Music in the mid-1970s. He didn't get in. "They said in Berklee that I wasn't good enough, so I responded by coming up with my own style," says Gurtu, who credits his urge to colour outside the lines to the rejections he faced in his early years. "It comes from not being accepted by your own people, not being accepted by the Americans. And in response to that, I had to be who I am."

However, things turned around soon for Gurtu after a chance meeting with American jazz trumpeter Don Cherry in Italy. The late jazz legend became Gurtu's mentor, encouraging him to find his own sound and identity. In 1976, he also spent some time in Munich, digging deep into African, Brazilian and Carnatic musical traditions and bringing ideas from them all into his own performances. "I was playing with African musicians, Belgian musicians, people from all over in the 1970s and 1980s," he remembers. "Then, John McLaughlin heard what I was doing, and I started playing with him."

Other high-profile collaborations with some of the biggest names in jazz and Indian classical soon followed—Joe Zawinul, Jan Garbarek, Bill Evans, Dave Holland, Zakir Hussain, Hariprasad Chaurasia, Pandit Ram Narayan and more. In 1988, he released his first solo record, an iconoclastic fusion album with his mother, Don Cherry, Ralph Towner, L. Shankar and Jonas Hellborg titled *Usfret*. Other critically acclaimed releases followed—a series of globe-trotting, cross-cultural solo records, trend-setting collaborations like the Bill Laswell-led *Tabla Beat Science* and the electronica-fusion album with Robert Miles titled *Miles_Gurtu*—establishing Gurtu as a jazz icon and a world music pioneer. He was voted the best percussionist in DownBeat's Critics Poll seven years running, a feat no Indian musician has equalled.

Back home, his success was met with indifference and occasional backlash. Purists criticised *Usfret* for not slavishly sticking to the Indian classical tradition. Even when things changed in the 1990s and 2000s, with world music becoming the talk of the town, he went largely unrecognised. Gurtu says he isn't bothered by the lack of accolades, but it must rankle a bit. Perhaps that's why he seems to be looking forward to his upcoming shows with both excitement and trepidation.

"I'm really looking forward to playing in my hometown again," he says. "It will be a very experimental show, I just hope it doesn't go over the heads of the audience. Some of my work—like [2001 album] *The Beat Of Love*—only got understood and appreciated 10 years later. But I can't change that. Ideas come to me, and I just execute them." ■

Bhanuj Kappal

GURTU CREDITS HIS URGE TO COLOUR OUTSIDE THE LINES TO THE REJECTIONS HE FACED IN HIS EARLY YEARS



of independent and mainstream film music in their careers. To that end, they've got everyone from sarod brothers Amaan and Ayaan Ali Bangash to firepower rap duo Seedhe Maut, Punjabi pop's affable star Diljit Dosanjh to composer-guitarist Tajdar Junaid, pop/film music favourite Armaan Malik and more, with a total of over 50 artistes.

While a relaunch in the ever-changing digital landscape is understandable, a renaming of the show feels somewhat gimmicky. Both Tewari and Coca-Cola India as well as South-west Asia vice-president of marketing Arnab Roy explained their reasons. Tewari says, "The idea was to tell the story of India since the last Coke Studio. We were a different country back then and we have emerged as a more confident, young nation, and the idea is to tell that story."

Roy explains that in the process of bringing back Coke Studio, they tried to understand consumers and the music industry in India. He points to young India's new musicians from smaller towns, and those who proudly wear their language as their artistic identity. "The music is very confident and cool, it can not only work in India but in any other place in the world [...] 'Bharat', we feel, is going to be a kind of defining culture in India and the economy in India over the next 10 to 20 years," Roy says.

That kind of individualism is welcome, but can Coke Studio Bharat or Coke Studio Tamil deliver a roaring hit like "Pasoori", the chartbuster by Ali Sethi and Shae Gill from season 14 of Coke Studio Pakistan? The song arguably allowed Sethi to snag a spot performing at California's Coachella Valley Music and Arts Festival in April.

Tewari is more than happy for "Pasoori" and points to how Coke Studio Pakistan producer-composer Xulfi is a dear friend and early collaborator. He says, "I'm hoping that one of our songs also kind of breaks like that, and probably rules the charts around the world. And if it does, that's really exciting for us."

With Coke Studio Bharat and Coke Studio Tamil dropping a new video every few weeks, one thing's for sure: we're about to see a whole lot of diverse music and maybe even future hits that will rule playlists, reels and the airwaves. ■

Anurag Tagat